Pastoral Psychology, Vol. 54, No. 4, March 2006 (© 2006)
DOI: 10.1007/s11089-005-0002-1

Grief Ministry as Homecoming: Framing Death from a Korean-American Perspective[1]

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Published online: 22 March 2006

Using the personal experience of a "homecoming" funerary journey from the U.S. to Korea, the author probes the cultural construction of familial bonds between the living and the dead in Korean and biblical (Genesis) funeral narratives. This article highlights the cultural differences between American and Korean funeral traditions — that is, (1) dying at a hospital vs. dying at home, (2) embalming vs. sup/yom (washing/binding of the corpse), (3) metal casket vs. wooden coffin, (4) committal vs. banhon (returning of the spirit) – to explore the religious and practical implications of the multicultural grieving process for pastoral care and grief ministry in which death is conceived as returning to the familial, cultural, and spiritual homes.

KEY WORDS: funeral narratives; homecoming; ritual; grief ministry; Korean culture.

The fear of death seems to be a universal phenomenon across cultures. And yet, people in different cultures have come up with the different ways to face it. In contrast to the widespread American manner of encouraging mourners to hide or control their grief and get back to work within a matter of days, mourners in some other cultures may be given a structure to encourage feeling their loss and remembering it long after the funeral. How we grieve and cope with the death of loved ones is reflected in and influenced by the way we do our funerals. The question which intrigues me is this: How do we in different cultures conceive death in rites of farewell and commemoration?

[1] The author's writing of this article has been done as a part of his grief work on his father's unexpected death. An earlier version of this article was published in the *Journal of Pastoral Care & Counseling* (Winter, 2003), and is here reprinted with the permission of the editor, Orlo Strunk, Jr., Ph.D.

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This essay investigates the general characteristics of the funerals in Genesis, contemporary American funerals, and Korean traditional funeral rites. These characteristics will show certain specific aspects of existence after death as perceived in ancient Hebrew, and contemporary American and Korean cultures. It is my contention that those perceptions of existence after death are closely associated with the cultural construction of familial relations. It should be noted that the after-life convictions may be formed not only by religious orientation but also by the cultural hermeneutics of pneumatology (i.e., how to understand spirits) which is for example, deeply embedded in the familial and ancestral bond in the Korean context.

Drawing upon my own funeral narratives and biblical death narratives, I will explore the religious and practical implications of the multicultural grieving process for pastoral care and grief ministry. If we want to truly minister to Asian (Korean) Americans in human loss, we should not neglect the significance of cultural awareness in how they "frame" death. For their thanatology (i.e., how to interpret death) expresses a part of their ontology (i.e., how to exist generation after generation, and eventually who they are).

THE FIRST FUNERAL IN THE BIBLE VS. MY FIRST AMERICAN FUNERAL

In the Hebrew Bible, the first funeral narrative is the story of the burial of Sarah in Genesis 23. This story deals with the question of interment for the first time and the burial place becomes a "family grave" in the patriarchal narratives. Jason S. Bray claims that chapter 23 of Genesis should be understood, in light of the theology of 'Priestly Editor'[4] by whom it was written, to be a paradigm for all future burials, most of which refer back to this one. He states: "Priestly Editor is concerned to demonstrate that for him death is a purely human affair, and that it in no way impinges on the theological. In this death scene there are no remembrances, no ritual acts, no future hope of an after-life: death is regarded as a [*sic*] impenetrable frontier. Thus can ancestor worship be discouraged" (Bray, 1993, p. 72). According to Bray, the Editor of chapter 23 is using the story of Sarah's burial to make an attack on false beliefs about the after-life and ancestral figures by asserting that death has nothing to do with either God or the cult. I am not in a position to fully assess this argument from a perspective of "historical criticism"; however, I would argue that from a perspective of "reader-response criticism," the Priestly Editor's theology (or Bray's interpretation of it) of the first biblical funeral narrative may not valid as a paradigm for our modern American Christian funerals while some other cultural traditions, I think, may have emerged

[4]The name is given to the author(s) of one of the sources found in the books of Genesis through Numbers since the authors appear to have come from priestly circles during the sixth century B.C.

as equally valid. "No remembrances, no ritual acts, no future hope of an after-life" merely to discourage ancestor worship can no longer serve as a paradigm for us as contemporary Christians today. In fact, we *remember* (and rejoice) in *resurrection* faith in our contemporary funerary *rituals*.

I attended a funeral in the United States for the first time when I was an M.Div. senior expecting to be ordained. In the New England Conference to which I belong, there's a highly-respected, retired Korean pastor. His wife died of cancer. She was a very active, renowned lay member of the conference of the United Methodist Church. Her funeral service was held at one of the largest churches in the conference, and there was a big turn-out. Most of the participants were Americans, although many of the Korean colleague ministers were there. From the start, I was taken aback. I was first amazed by the service bulletin. On the front page, I saw the words, "in celebration of so-and-so's life." Throughout the service, the presiding minister often said "Let us celebrate" or "Let us rejoice," and he invited people to share memories of the deceased. Many people stood up and told us funny stories relating to the life of the deceased. All of sudden, people in the sanctuary went wild with excitement and laughter. I was overwhelmed: "Are they crazy? How could they do that to the survivors?" The final hymn was a real shock to me: "Marching to Zion." In the middle of singing, people began clapping, and this was the final blow to my image of grieving in a funeral service. I found no one weeping there as I had expected. At the time, I was not able to understand such behavior because it was so different from the way people are wailing and weeping at Korean funerals. Even in Genesis 23, the only visible scene is: "Abraham went in to mourn for Sarah and to weep for her." Even though Jewish tradition has distinguished a good death (i.e., a fast death following the age of eighty) from a bad one (Talmud, Moed Katan 28A), the Talmud establishes mourning as a mandatory response on the part of the survivors (Ponet, 1996, p. 135).

HOW CAN A FUNERAL BE FESTIVE?

Later on, I began to see some parallels between the "festive motif" of the Christian memorial service and the Korean traditional funeral process.

Here in the U.S. we usually have a two-hour-visiting period for the wake, typically in the funeral home. In Korea, in contrast, condolers visit the *home* of the deceased as soon as they hear of the person's death. The visiting lasts around 70 hours, that is, usually three days, and most condolers stay and eat and drink and sometimes play traditional card games for three days, day and night. In one old tradition, a *Sorikkoon* (Korean traditional folk singer) was invited to lead the dirge singing and sometimes cheer up the condolers and survivors. Simply put, it seems that the visiting hours in the Korean funerary process aim to divert "the mourners from their grief so no one has to acknowledge that one who was once present is no longer" (Gerson, 1984, p. 3).

My question is: Why do American Christians and Koreans try to perform their funerals in a festive manner? The Christian funeral service is based on resurrection faith. It focuses on Christ's victory over sin and death. So the funeral service is a corporate act of the people of God, where God is thanked for the life and the witness of the deceased. The basic premise is that the service commits the deceased person to God's keeping. Such committal points to Christian belief in the resurrection of the person.

Do Koreans also have this resurrection faith to underscore the festive aspects of their funeral? The answer is no. While the Western view of life and death is theistic, the Korean view of life and death is neither theistic nor atheistic. It can better be stated as *non-theistic*. It is not something deduced from God, but something converged into *cosmos*. That is, the other world for Koreans is not separated from this world, but is an extension of this world. In Christianity, the other world is quite different from this world on an ontological level as well as epistemological level. And yet, for Koreans, such a spacial distinction does not exist. For Koreans, the funeral rite is not a ritual of eternal farewell. I think that the most strikingly different part of the Korean funeral is the rite for the *returning* spirit after burial.

The Korean funeral rites — especially the rite for returning spirit — reveal several peculiar understandings about the spirit. In the old funeral tradition, it is believed that there are three spirits in the body of the deceased. After death the three spirits are separated from each other. One is carried to heaven or the other world. Another spirit stays in the body. The third spirit stays in box for the spirit, the *honback sangja*, which is made of strings or paper. After burial, the box of the spirit and the ancestor tablet are preserved for two years in the mourning shrine at home. Today, not many Koreans keep this spirit box at home. But I feel that Koreans still hold the belief that their ancestor spirits live together with them in this world.

For instance, Koreans are afraid to visit a public cemetery alone. I grew up hearing a myriad of ghost stories about things which happened at burial grounds. In almost every town in America, we can easily find a cemetery *within* the town. It seems that the presence of the cemetery does not bother people at all. For Americans, it is simply a place to bury the corpse. But Koreans never locate a cemetery within the town. Korean cemeteries are usually settled in secluded places. Why? Koreans tend to believe that the dead literally live around the tomb and some souls are still hovering there. Some evil spirits may harm people.

Many anthropologists identify two types of spirits in Korea, namely (1) the evil spirit or ghost and (2) the good or benevolent ancestor. The distinction between these two spirits is generally held to be "the manner in which they met their deaths" (Lee, 1984, p. 199). For example, "bad spirits" are the product of abnormal deaths, such as suicides or accidents, and they are held to have died outside the home. They wander around the world and harm people. "Good spirits," however, have lived long lives and died normal deaths in their homes; they become ancestor spirits

which protect their descendents and family. Based on this mutual dependence and connection between the living and the dead (offspring and ancestor), people in East Asia have long developed the idea of ancestor veneration (worship). In this sense, for Koreans, we can say that the living and the dead live together in this world. Accordingly, some portions of the Korean funeral process might have been developed in a festive manner, since death is not framed as parting but returning.

MY FATHER'S "HOMECOMING" FUNERAL: CLASHING TRADITIONS

After graduating from college, I came to the U.S. for my graduate studies. When I was about to earn an M.Div, my parents planned to visit us in the U.S. for the first time. All of sudden my father had a stroke. It was a warning-type of stroke and he recovered soon, but his doctor advised him not to travel abroad, so he decided not to come. A few years later, I became a full-time minister serving an Anglo congregation in Maine. I bought plane tickets for my parents to come visit my first church, see their newborn granddaughter and celebrate the hundredth day of the baby's life. We were all excited.

Before this long-awaited encounter could come to pass, I got a phone call from my mother that my father had another stroke. I was speechless. To make matters worse, I was unable to leave the States to see my father. At the time, I was in the process of getting a green card, and green card applicants are not allowed to travel abroad during that process. It was real torture. A year and a half passed, the card came through, and finally I was allowed to visit Korea. On my return to Maine, I brought my parents with me. Even though my father was in a wheelchair, he was very happy to visit me and my parish. I planned to have my parents stay with me for about a year. All my parishioners warmly welcomed my folks. On the third Sunday after my parents arrived, my father had another massive stroke. We took him to the hospital. He passed away in the hospital the same day.

The first thing we had to do was bring his human remains to his home in Korea for a funeral. Let me highlight some of the cultural differences between two funeral traditions that my family had to face: (1) dying at hospital vs. dying at home, (2) embalming vs. *sup/yom* (washing/binding of the body of the deceased), (3) metal casket vs. wooden coffin, (4) committal vs. *banhon* (returning of the spirit).

Dying at Hospital vs. Dying at Home

The most important element of the "good" death in Korea is that people should die *at home,* surrounded by all children and family members. When a

person is about to die, he or she is brought by family members to a deathbed in the warmest part of a bed room.

One of the most imperative obligations of children is *imjong*, which means to watch at the deathbed of their parents. Sometimes, people will place a little piece of cotton (*sokkweng*) on the mouth of dying person so as to be able to check the last breath. The cotton would stop quivering at the moment of last breath. After death is recognized, one member of the family will then take a white shirt of the deceased out into the garden, and climb onto the roof. There he or she will call out the name of the deceased in a loud voice and repeat the word *bok* (literally, "return") three times. The aim of this ceremony called the *kobok* (calling back the spirit of the dead) is actually to announce the death to the other people in town. Today, not many Koreans practice *kobok* in their funeral rites; however, they still keep the sense of that ritual by extending their family ritual to the community.

In the past half-century, the primary place of death in our culture has been changed from the home to the hospital (Aries, 1974, pp. 87–88). This "displacement of the site of death," as Eric Krakauer puts it, has happened "not by design but rather because of the irresistible movement of technological development" (Krakauer, 1996, p. 22). It is said that 80 percent of Americans die in the hospital. William McCullough, a surgeon with theological background, says, "This is not, however, the best place to bring the dying. Doctors (especially surgeons) and nurses frequently see death as failure. Our job is to prevent death. When we are unsuccessful, as often occurs, it is very difficult to step out of the role of *preventer* and into the role of *comforter*" (McCullough, 1996, p. 186, *emphasis added*). For me and my family, attending to my dying father at the hospital was more miserable, not because we were told, "Your dad won't make it," but because we were physically, emotionally, culturally disengaged from our *home*.

Embalming vs. *Sup*/*Yom* (Washing/Binding of the Corpse)

The most important rites in the Korean funeral ritual are the *sup* (washing of the body of the deceased) and the *yom* (binding). The naked body of the deceased is washed with a piece of cloth or cotton that has been soaked in warm water. After the body has been washed it is bound with a long cloth known as *yom*.

Koreans never embalm the corpse, but I had no other option for my father since the shipment of human remains to a foreign country requires five embalmer affidavits indicating that proper embalming procedures have been applied. This is reminiscent of the funeral of Jacob in the last chapter of Genesis. When Jacob died, Joseph in Egypt had to secure a permission from Pharaoh to leave the country with his brothers so that they could bury their father in the "family grave" in Hebron in the land of Canaan, which was purchased by Abraham for his wife Sarah. Even before he requested permission from Pharaoh, Joseph commanded

the Egyptian physicians to embalm the remains of his father Jacob: "They spent forty days in doing this, for that is the time required for embalming. And the Egyptians wept for him seventy days" (Genesis 50:3). It is generally assumed that seventy days included the period of actual embalming as well as the periods of rituals such as mourning, ceremonies, and other burial preparation. "It has been rightly emphasized that the ceremonial and religious aspects of embalming were extremely important to the Egyptians, being the key to the continuance of life in the hereafter. Accordingly, the various ritualized performances attending death were the reason why the process of embalming and burial lasted so long" (Jones, 1992, p. 493).

In this sense, Shubert Spero sees the funeral of Jacob as a joint Hebrew-Egyptian affair (1998, pp. 20–25). If we posit that Egyptian funerary practices were bound up with the idolatrous Egyptian religion, a question arises: Was it right to expose his father's remains to those disrespectful performances? As Spero notes, perhaps Joseph had no choice! He just had to go home to bury his father: So did I.

Embalming is totally contrary to the Korean custom that permits the corpse to decompose into soil as soon as possible. Even if Asians do not hold the belief that the Creator formed human beings from the dust of the ground, they believe that they should return to the dust of the ground. It would appear that they follow biblical dictum, — that is, God's statement regarding Adam's fate: "By the sweat of your face you shall eat bread until you return to the ground, for out of it you were taken; you are dust, and to dust you shall return" (Genesis 3:19). In this sense, I believe that the Korean way of burial is more biblical than embalming. This is why the practice of embalming is also against Jewish tradition. It is not surprising that very pious Jews never embalm their dead (Ponn, 1991, p. 220).

Why then do Christians embalm the body? I do not think that they follow the biblical narrative of the funeral of Jacob and Joseph, the only specific mention of the embalming of the corpse in the Bible. My hunch is that Christian embalming practice is based on their resurrection belief. Most Christians believe that resurrection of the dead is the resurrection of the body and spirit. I surmise that this idea of *bodily resurrection* makes people want to keep their bodies intact as much as possible. In our grieving process, this Christian ideal of bodily resurrection has been comforting. To me, the ritual of embalming, however, is seen as a symbolic act that expresses *denial* of death, rather than acceptance of death. Furthermore, making up the face of the deceased and dressing the corpse in everyday attire at the wake is obviously seen as some denial of death: the departed still look "alive" to the survivors and visitors at the visiting hours. Koreans never apply any make-up to the deceased, and the corpse is always dressed in a shroud (grave clothes). At the visiting hours in Korea, the family members and relatives of the deceased are required to attend to witness the practice of *yom* (binding of the dead body), which

might be a painful moment for the survivors to see the process and accept the death of the loved ones. It seems to me that this custom of *yom* represents a symbolic act that urges the acceptance of death and physical separation. Many Christians may see the resurrection of the body as "overcoming," not denying death. What I am arguing here is that the religious belief or imagery of a comforting nature may have made the acceptance of death, separation, and disintegration almost impossible to have religious meaning.

Metal Casket vs. Wooden Coffin

Since Koreans believe bodily decay should occur rapidly following death, they never use a metal casket. There is no such thing in Korea. But the U.S. Law requires the use of a sealed metal casket to ship human remains to Korea. At first, my mother really felt uncomfortable with the metal casket. Why?

Koreans prefer the custom of *booboo hapchang*, burying husband and wife in one grave. They believe that they will keep the same marital relationship in the other world as in this world. Again, the other world is not disconnected but an extended reality of this world. When the corpse is put into a coffin, family members add some travel money, the favorite items of the deceased, or the favorite items of family members. My mother lamented over the fact that because of the metal casket (which will never decompose into soil) she would not be able to touch her husband after she would later be buried with him. Initially we decided to replace the metal casket with a wooden coffin before the burial in Korea, but my mother changed her mind after she saw my father lying in the metal casket. She told me that she felt he would feel more comfortable wearing his best suit than being bound in a narrow wooden coffin. In order to fit in the wooden coffin, we would have had to bind his body tightly.

I empathized with Joseph and his brothers as they set out on their "homecoming" funerary journey to Canaan with the feeling that they had not violated Hebrew burial traditions. In the burial narratives of the Patriarchs, we have found neither life after death nor the continued existence of the soul. The Lord said to Abram in Genesis 15:15: "As for yourself, you shall go to your ancestors in peace; you shall be buried in a good old age." In the language of the Hebrew Bible, death means to be "gathered to his people" (Genesis 25:8). The "whole generation was gathered to their ancestors" (Judges 2:10a). "When your days are fulfilled to go to be with your ancestors" (1 Chronicles 17:11a). It should be emphasized that "death was seen as some sort of reunion with one's forefathers, not only in physical terms of burial in a family tomb but in some sense in an afterlife" (Spero, 1998, p. 22). The point being made is that there is no mention of any veneration being given to any ancestral figures, but there is a strong bond being given to all the ancestors and descendents (*all* their sons) in the manner of burial of the Patriarchs and even in an after-life.

Committal vs. *Banhon* (Returning of the Spirit)

While the Christian funeral service ends with committal of the physical remains, the Korean funeral does not end there. After burial, the chief mourner takes the box for the spirit and the ancestor tablet home. When the chief mourner and other male mourners return home, the female mourners come outside their gate, welcoming them by wailing. The box for the spirit and ancestor tablet are put into the mourning shrine along with a table of food offerings and a small table holding an incense burner.

In the old tradition of the family shrine there are several ancestor tablets, from parents up to the fourth generation. Traditionally, after the second anniversary of the death day (*daesang*), the mourners withdraw from the shrine and they change from mourning clothes to normal attire. The family performs the rite of good fortune (*kil-je*) on the one hundredth day after the second death anniversary. With this rite the long process of funerary rites is totally over (Lee, 1984, pp. 203–204). I observed that my mother would not wear colorful clothes for two years after my father died. Koreans continue to give great importance to this memorial anniversary of their ancestors.

When Christianity was first introduced in Korea, American missionaries forced Korean converts not to practice the ancestor commemoration ceremony because they believed it was idolatry. This is still theologically debated among Korean Christian denominations. As the Korean funeral demonstrates, Koreans can never be separated from their ancestors. Even death cannot separate us from the familial bond.

In the narrative of Jacob's funeral, it appears that one of the most essential elements in the Hebrew tradition was burial of the father by all of his sons in an ancestral grave. It signifies the fact that Hebrew people too focused on generational unity and continuity of familial relations in their burial traditions.

PASTORAL IMPLICATIONS OF FRAMING DEATH AS HOMECOMING

Among Christians, particularly Christian missionaries, there has always been a misunderstanding of commemoration rites and customs in Asian cultures. Those rites are not incompatible with Christian faith. The way Asian people "frame" death in ritual is similar to that of the Patriarchs in the Hebrew Bible. Abraham J. Heschel points to the Jewish meaning of death as "homecoming." He asserts: "Our greatest problem is not how to continue but how to return. . . When life is an answer, death is a homecoming." (1974, p. 73). For both Korean and Jewish traditions, death has to do with "returning" since they believe death is not understood as the end of being. As Heschel puts it, "death, then, is not simply man's [*sic*] coming to

an end. It is also entering a beginning" (p. 59). The death rituals in both traditions can be simply stated as "homecoming" rituals.

How do we then apply this "homecoming" perspective to our pastoral context in terms of grief ministry? My observation is that the American pattern of grieving found in the Christian funeral may have been embedded in the American cultural imperatives of *autonomy* and *self-control*. For Americans, words like "reliance" and "dependence" may come to hold only negative connotations — failure to be autonomous (Lim, 1996, p. 74). Even in the rites of farewell, it would appear that Americans firmly hold their cultural ideals (i.e., independence from their ancestors, and refusal to be controlled by death as an overwhelming defeat). That may be why they hesitate to perform certain rituals of commemoration. It should be noted that ancestors were not regarded as supreme beings in cultures where ancestor commemoration has been practiced (e.g., East Asian, Jewish, and African cultures). Ancestors in these cultures may be seen as having power over the living; however, they are not God-like. They are *coming home* by means of their homecoming rituals, celebrated by descendants. They are *coming home* into familial bond and generational unity.

Gerson observes that "death and mourning ceremonies in America are all too often vestigial and devoid of meaning" (p. 2). I think that we need to do more than "celebrate" the life of the deceased in the death rites. I have encouraged those who lost loved ones to have some times of profound wailing in the prefuneral meeting. And I have preached on the therapeutic, theological significance of tears. I compared the attitude of disciples with that of Mary after they discovered the empty tomb. What did the disciples do? They were indeed people of "self-control." They just went home! (John 20: 10)

Meanwhile, Mary stayed and wept. She met Jesus, the resurrected Christ right there. The message may be "when you feel like crying, shed tears, tears of "yearning" like Mary: "Where's my Lord? Where's my hope?"

CONCLUSION

One of the important tasks in grief ministry is to enable people to find their *familial, cultural, and spiritual homes* because they may be losing their homes as they lose their loved ones. The "displacement of the site of death" from the home to the hospital in our culture suggests much fear in those who witness the dying. Moreover, medical practices have lengthened the dying process from hours or days to months or years.

The concept of hospice care (at home or in a home-like setting) for terminally ill patients was brought by Dr. Cicely Saunders from England to the United States in 1963. Inspired by Saunders, Florence S. Wald, who was formerly dean of Yale's School of Nursing, offered the first hospice in the United States, the Connecticut Hospice in 1974. Twenty years later, there were more than two thousand hospices

and palliative-care institutions around the country. Drawing upon the emergence of hospice care in the United States, Wald asserts:

> The patient has not only a physiologic dimension but also social and spiritual dimensions. Pain, for example, comes not only from the changes in the body organs and systems but also from spiritual needs or from entanglements in social relationships. It is not only the patient who needs help, but also those left behind – the family and friends (1996, p. 88).

Medical doctors and nurses are learning how to help in the process of dying by creating a more accepting and sensitive institutional environment. For those coming from different cultures, we as pastoral care givers might need to gather and learn the description of non-Western ways of "framing" death to use in our pastoral care. Those left behind need to come to their *own* familial, cultural, and spiritual homes. It poses a formidable challenge for work with urban dwellers who may not have discernable family ties, living in foreign cultures, and do not define themselves as "spiritual" nor as having a spiritual home.

More occasions for re-membering will be helpful, especially over extended periods of time. Pastoral contact with the bereaved family should not be limited to a prefuneral meeting and to the funeral and committal service. Ministers need to keep track of the death anniversaries of their parishioners. For example, I send letters at Christmas time to parishioners who lost loved ones during the year, and I honor memorial anniversaries of my church members. Just as many ministers offer communion at nursing homes or homes of the shut-ins using the portable communion set, I offer home communion at the memorial anniversary of parishioners.

Christ shared his life and membership in the divine family through his blood. This might be compared to the transmission of eternal life in a familial lineage. My father's homecoming ritual taught me that familial, cultural, and spiritual homes are one. We are always on the way home: the familial, cultural, and spiritual homes.

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